

# "If Your Team Never Fails, It Isn't Learning"

Ron Friedman | Harvard Business Review | YouTube search: "If Your Team Never Fails It Isn't Learning HBR"

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Period: \_\_\_\_\_ Date: \_\_\_\_\_

## ■ WHAT THIS VIDEO IS ABOUT

Ron Friedman is a psychologist who has spent his career studying what separates high-performing teams from average ones. His research — one of the most-read studies in Harvard Business Review history — surveyed thousands of professionals across dozens of industries. His core argument is counterintuitive: the best teams are not the ones that avoid failure. They are the ones that learn from it faster than everyone else.

## Review Questions — Answer as You Watch or Immediately After

*Answer in the space provided. Complete sentences are required.*

### Question 1 — The Counterintuitive Finding

What do most people assume separates great teams from average ones — and how does Friedman's research challenge that assumption? What does he say actually matters most?

### Question 2 — Failure and Learning

Friedman says a team that never fails "isn't learning." In your own words, explain the connection he draws between failure and long-term team performance. Why is avoiding failure actually a risk?

### Question 3 — Psychological Safety

Friedman describes psychological safety as a key ingredient of high-performing teams. What does it mean, what does it look like in practice, and what happens to a team that lacks it?

### Question 4 — Experimentation as a Feature

Friedman argues the best teams treat experimentation as a feature, not a flaw. Give one specific example of what that looks like on a real workplace team — and explain why most teams resist it.



*Read the scenario carefully. Respond in complete sentences. One-sentence answers will not receive full credit.*

## Scenario Question

A welding crew at a fabrication shop has been using the same process for cutting and fitting pipe for three years. A new team member tries a slightly different technique on a small job and it works — faster and cleaner. She mentions it to the crew lead, who shuts it down: "That's not how we do it here. If it's not broken, don't fix it." The team goes back to the old method. Six months later, a competing shop wins a major contract partly because of a faster fitting process.

Based on what Friedman argues in the video, what did this team lose by avoiding the risk of a new approach? What should the crew lead have done differently, and why does a team that never fails eventually fall behind? Respond in at least 4 complete sentences.

